

English Quantified Partitives are derived by Extraposition plus NP-deletion

Some English quantifiers may appear in *quantified partitives* (1). But not all may (1c).

- (1) a. Many/some of the cakes
b. Much/some of the cake
c. I ate {all/each/*every} of the fish.

There are two main extant analyses of these constructions. One is the ‘surface true’ analysis, in which the quantifier takes a PP-argument (Lobeck, 1995, Barker, 1998, Gagnon, 2013, Shin, 2016, or a DP with *of*-insertion; Matthewson, 2000, 2001):

- (2) [DP some [PP of the cake]]

An alternative analysis takes there to be a silent noun serving as the quantifier’s argument (Jackendoff, 1968, Hoeksema, 1984, Kayne, 2007, 2025, Dobrovie-Sorin and Giurgea, 2021, i.a.). The silent noun is often treated as meaning something like ‘unit’.

- (3) a. Much UNIT of the cake (Jackendoff, 1968)
b. Much AMOUNT of the cake (Kayne, 2007)

The observed distribution of NP-modifiers in quantified partitives poses a problem for both of these analyses. I will argue that the best analysis includes a duplicated noun which is deleted (see also Zamparelli, 1998, Sauerland and Yatsushiro, 2004, Falco and Zamparelli, 2019). But my proposal differs from previous analyses as it is not merely the *head* of the NP which is silent, but the whole NP which is deleted.

- (4) Many [_{NP}-cakes] of the cakes

For simplicity, I talk as if all of these quantifiers are in D, and that the complement of D is always NP, but this is for expository convenience rather than a substantive commitment. By ‘NP-deletion’, I mean that the whole complement of the quantifier is deleted (unlike the NP-deletion proposal in Ionin et al., 2006, where an NP-part of a multi-layered NP is deleted). What is crucial in my proposal is deletion of NP or a phrase containing NP. It is

compatible with my analysis to assume that the quantifier heads NumP for some cases. It is also compatible with my analysis to posit more functional heads between N and the quantifier. But phrasal deletion of NP is essential. It is what allows my analysis to capture – and unify – two generalizations which I illustrate in Section 2. First, only the quantifiers which may appear ‘bare’ – without an overt restrictor – may appear in quantified partitives. Second, only extraposable NP-modifiers may modify quantified partitives.

1 Objections to silent noun and ‘surface true’ analyses of quantified partitives

The objections to both analyses of quantified partitives come from the distribution of NP-modifiers. In English, quantified partitives allow prepositional phrases and relative clauses, but not adjectives (for similar observations, see Jackendoff, 1977; Gagnon, 2013).

(5) The bakery produced ten cakes.

- | | |
|--|---------------------|
| a. Some iced cakes were on the shelf. | (AP; not partitive) |
| b. Some of them (with cherries on top) were on the shelf. | (PP; partitive) |
| c. Some of them (which were iced by Al) were on the shelf. | (RC; partitive) |
| d. Some (*iced) of them were on the shelf. | (*AP; partitive) |

In this section, I argue that the silent noun analysis overgenerates, and that the ‘surface true’ analysis undergenerates. In the next section, I turn to a finer-grained characterization of which NP-modifiers can appear, arguing that this motivates the NP-deletion analysis.

1.1 Silent noun analyses overgenerate

Emphasizing facts like (5d), Gagnon (2013) and Shin (2016) object to a silent noun in quantified partitives, since (6)’s ungrammaticality would have to be stipulated:

(6) *some [_{NP} iced $\emptyset_N$ of them]

Can English adjectives otherwise modify silent nouns? When they occur bare in plural definite contexts, it seems they modify [_{NP} PEOPLE] (Kayne, 2017, Merchant, 2023):

- (7) CONTEXT: at a kennel, looking at dogs.
The very obedient #(ones) will be rewarded with treats.

As the reading obtained without *ones* can only be about very obedient people, not the very obedient dogs, it suggests the existence of silent $[_{NP} \text{ PEOPLE}]$. So, the ungrammaticality of (6) cannot be chalked up to the unmodifiability of silent nouns in general (see also Section 3.3 for Spanish adjectives modifying silent N), meaning it poses a genuine problem for the silent noun hypothesis.

Shin also objects that the silent noun hypothesis cannot straightforwardly explain why the silent noun is not available as the restrictor to any quantifier:

- (8) * {every/a/the/no/my} $\emptyset_N$ of them

The silent noun hypothesis faces two distinct overgeneration problems. Perhaps the quantifiers in quantified partitives simply optionally select partitive PPs, as in (9):

- (9) $[_{DP_1} \text{ all } [_{PP} \text{ of } [_{DP_2} \text{ them}]]]$ (Gagnon, 2013, Shin, 2016)

But the proposal in (9) solves the overgeneration problem at the cost of undergeneration.

1.2 ‘Surface true’ analyses undergenerate

The ‘surface true’ analysis provides no appropriate adjunction site for relative clauses and prepositional phrases, such as those in the sentences below:

- (10) Al iced some of the cakes. *All of them with vanilla frosting* are beautiful.

- (11) *All of them that had white frosting* looked delicious.

These are restrictive modifiers of the head noun, and not appositives: (11) means that all the cakes that had white frosting looked delicious, not that all the cakes looked delicious, and they have white frosting.

Furthermore, polarity items are licensed in the relative clause by negative quantifiers:

(12) None of them [that Al (ever) put (any) decorations on] looked less than perfect.

Appositives, on the other hand, do not allow for NPIs, as shown in (13) (assuming proper names can be modified only by appositive relative clauses; Jackendoff, 1977).

(13) a. At the party, no one greeted men who (ever) wore (any) colorful socks.

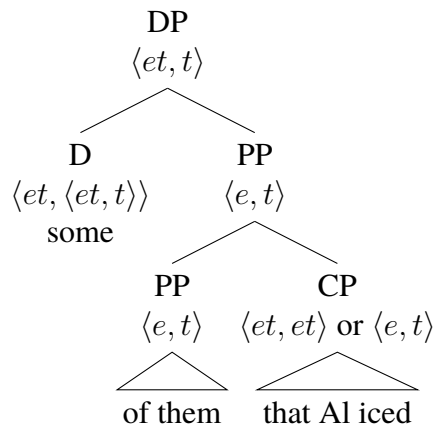
b. At the party, no one greeted John, who (*ever) wore (*any) colorful socks.

The modifiers in (10)-(12) are not appositive, then. What are they modifying? The hypothesis in (9) gives us only three options: the quantificational DP, DP_1 ; the partitive PP; and the partitioned DP, DP_2 . I will now show that none of these are appropriate adjunction sites, so the syntactic structure must be richer than in (9).

In many English dialects, pronouns allow modification, as in *he who drank from my coffee cup*, but only with a ‘grandiose’ feeling (Elbourne, 2005). This is absent in the above constructions. Some English dialects allow for relative clauses and PPs to modify pronouns directly (allowing *them with vanilla frosting*). But the constructions in (10)-(12) are possible even in dialects (such as mine) that do not allow **them with vanilla frosting*. So the relative clause does not modify the partitioned DP.

If the relative clause were adjoined not to the partitioned DP but to the partitive PP restricting the quantifier, the semantic composition would at least proceed smoothly.

(14) (to be rejected)

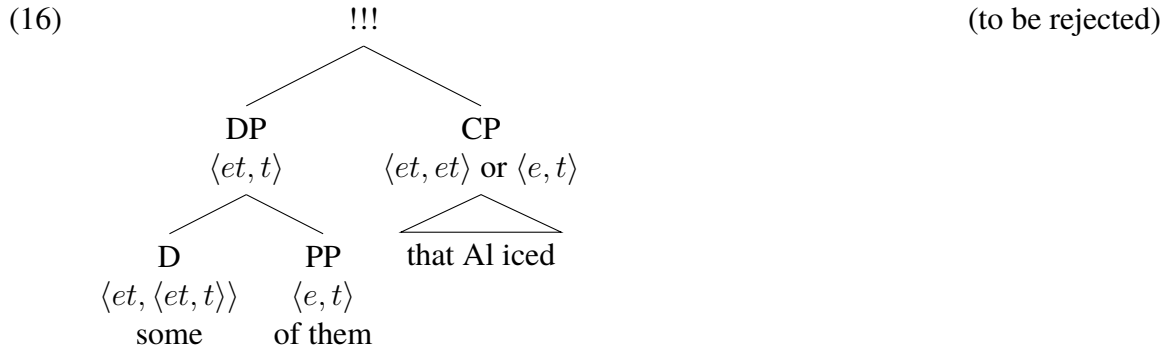


However, this hypothesis predicts that [of them that Al iced] is a PP-constituent. The partitive-PP cannot function as if it is modified by the relative clause (as observed by Jackendoff, 1977 and Gagnon, 2013):

- (15) a. Of them, [the group that you met] aren't here anymore.
 b. *Of them that you met, [the group *t*] aren't here anymore.

If (14) was the right constituent structure, fronting would be required to target the lower PP node while being *unable* to target the higher one. Such a rule is unformulable.

This leaves only one possibility – that the relative clause is adjoined high, to the quantificational DP, DP₁. However, under conventional assumptions, the semantic composition fails if the relative clause is adjoined there:



If the quantifier could instead be type $\langle et, \langle et, \langle et, t \rangle \rangle \rangle$, this would not be a problem (Bach and Cooper, 1978). Should we want to maintain generalized quantifier theory where determiners take exactly two arguments (Barwise and Cooper, 1981), it is a problem.

The syntax of quantified partitives proposed in Gagnon (2013) and Shin (2016) makes three positions for NP-modifiers available in principle. None of these work, either for syntactic or semantic reasons. But NP-modifiers are attested in quantified partitives, so, these accounts undergenerate. There must be an additional silent adjunction-site for NP-modifiers. I will now turn to bare quantifiers to establish an independent generalization:

only extrapositionable modifiers are permitted in these. I will then build on the observation that the same quantifiers are permitted bare as are allowed in the partitive. I show how the NP-deletion analysis can account for all of these facts.

2 Only the possibly-bare quantifiers and the extrapositionable modifiers are allowed

2.1 The bareness generalization

The quantifiers which can appear in quantified partitives may also appear ‘bare’; without an overt restrictor (Hoeksema, 1984, Kayne, 2007, Shin, 2016), as shown in (17a). But not all quantifiers can appear bare, or with the partitive (17b).

- (17) a. I fed {all, both, each, few, most, none, several, some, three...} (of the sheep)
 b. *I fed {a, every, the, no} (of the sheep)

If a quantifier can appear in the quantified partitive, it can appear without an overt NP restrictor. I call this the bareness generalization.

In (17a), the NP (or partitive PP) restricting the quantifiers is only optionally realized, despite the fact that there is no general optionality of NP realization in English:

- (18) a. *No linguist likes syntax, but every likes phonology.
 b. Good linguists like phonology but bad *(ones) don’t. (adapted, Kayne, 2007)

So, if there can be a silent NP restricting the quantifiers in (17a), its licensing is *lexically* conditioned by that set of quantifiers (Lobeck, 1995).

Recall that the silent noun analysis fails to derive the bareness generalization (i.e., block (8) without stipulation):

- (8) *{every/a/the/no/my} $\emptyset_N$ of them

An analysis of quantified partitives should not render it coincidence that the same quantifiers which may appear in partitives may appear bare (as the silent N analysis does).

I take bareness to be a one-way generalization: if D_1 is available in the quantified partitive [D_1 of DP], it is available bare. This excludes from the discussion the Saxon genitive 's, the demonstrative *this*, and adjectives like *the other*_A, which do not allow the partitive. I comment on comparatives and superlatives in Section 3.2.

2.2 Bare quantifiers allow only extrapositionable modifiers; NP-deletion explains this

First, note that when the antecedent noun c-selects a certain P (Merchant, 2019), only that P is available after a bare quantifier (19). This suggests that the noun is there, elided:

(19) Al has no pride {in/*on/*about} his car. He has some pride {in/*on/*...} his house.

Now we turn to NP-modifiers. Bare quantifiers (dis)allow the same ones as the partitives (compare (20) to (5)):

- | | | | |
|------|----|---|-------|
| (20) | a. | Some (with cherries on top) were on the shelf. | (PP) |
| | b. | Some (which were iced by Al) were on the shelf. | (RC) |
| | c. | Some (*iced) were on the shelf. | (*AP) |

It is not rightwardness that explains the distribution (cf. Jackendoff, 1971). Other rightward modifiers like *a*-adjectives and reduced relative clauses are unavailable:

- (21) The sleep study we are running is going well. Look at the participants.
- | | |
|----|---|
| a. | {The ones/*some} asleep will be woken up soon. |
| b. | Some ??(that) the experimenters examined showed interesting data. |

In this, bare quantifiers differ from 'indefinite' quantifiers, which allow adjectives (Abney, 1987, Larson and Marušič, 2004, i.a.):

(22) Anyone/someone/no-one asleep was woken up by the experimenters.

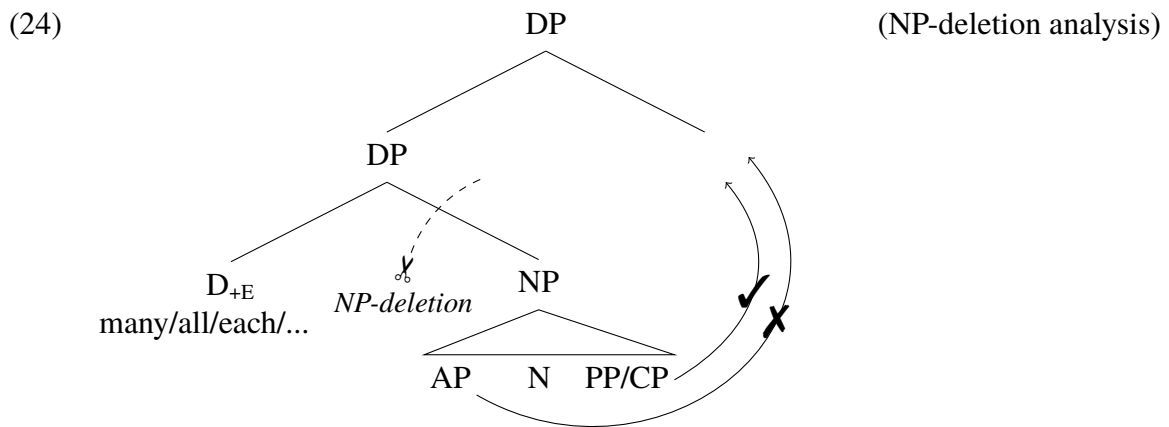
Why are fewer modifiers allowed by bare quantifiers than by indefinite quantifiers, then?

We can relate this to the fact that only PPs and unreduced relative clauses can extrapose.

- (23) a. I met the participants yesterday *(that) the experimenters examined.
 b. I met the participants yesterday from the subject-pool.
 c. *I met [the participants t_1] yesterday [enthusiastic/asleep]₁.

If bare quantifiers involved phrasal deletion of the NP-restrictor, as already suggested by (19), only those modifiers that can move out of the NP before deletion could appear. This is a widely accepted property of ellipsis (Ross, 1969, Hankamer and Sag, 1976, Merchant, 2001, 2023, Saab, 2019, i.m.a.): ellipsis of XP does not bleed movement out of XP.

Assuming that extraposition is movement (whether it is rightward movement (Ross, 1967, Drummond, 2009) or multiple steps of leftward movement (as in Kayne, 1994, 2005)), extraposition of NP-modifiers should not be bled by NP-deletion. Given that only those modifiers which can extrapose – i.e., move – can appear, and given that there is an NP missing, it is natural to tie these facts together. The fact that the modifiers can move is what allows them to escape the ellipsis site:



- (25) a. Some [_{NP} participants t_1] [that the experimenters examined]₁ are here.
 b. *Some [_{NP} t_1 participants] [enthusiastic]₁ are here.

If N were merely silent, then we would make no predictions about which modifiers can appear. I also assume the quantifiers which may appear bare are lexically marked as op-

tionally bearing the ‘E(IIipsis)-feature’ (Merchant, 2001), which triggers deletion of their NP-complement. Thus, NP-deletion, and no other analysis, makes the prediction that only extraposable modifiers may appear. The data above shows that this is borne out.

A reviewer asks about complement-taking adjectives, providing examples like (26):

(26) a. %I met parents yesterday [_{AP} ready to participate].

b. %Some ready to participate

Both I and my informants find the above examples sharply degraded. What my analysis predicts is that a speaker’s judgment for (26a) – extraposition of AP – should track their judgment for (26b) – AP in a quantified partitive. In this reviewer’s grammar, both are acceptable, and in my grammar, neither is. This is as my analysis predicts.

If a speaker permits an NP-modifier with a bare quantifier, then they also permit its extraposition. My analysis captures this generalization by invoking phrasal deletion. This is the ingredient which lets us capture the fine-grained distribution of NP-modifiers with bare quantifiers. Now we extend this to quantified partitives.

3 Unifying bare quantifiers and quantified partitives with NP-deletion

Rightward adjectives and reduced relative clauses are unavailable in quantified partitives (but PPs and unreduced relative clauses are available as shown earlier in (5)):

(27) a. Some of them *(who are) asleep are being monitored by a scientist.

b. Some of them *(that) the scientists examined showed interesting data.

That is, the NP-modifiers obey extraposition. This serves as a diagnostic for NP-deletion. Thus, I propose quantified partitives involve extraposition of the partitive-PP:

(28) Some [_{NP} participants t_1 t_2] [of them]₁ [* (that) the scientists]₂ examined...

The derivation above would explain why only those quantifiers which may bear the E-feature can participate in quantified partitives. As quantified partitives just are extraposed

partitive PPs which are stranded after deletion, only those quantifiers which may delete their NP-complements may participate. This is the bareness generalization. Thus, by allowing NP-deletion in quantified partitives, we derive and unify the Bareness and Extrapolability generalizations.

So quantified partitives are a special case of bare quantifiers, with extraposition of the partitive-PP preceding NP-deletion. This distinguishes my analysis from similar analyses such as Zamparelli's (1998) and Sauerland and Yatsushiro's (2004). They propose a deleted N-head, but not extraposition or phrasal deletion. There is also an advantage over the analysis proposed in Ionin et al. (2006). They treat the partitive-PP as right-adjoined to an NP-layer above a deleted NP:

(29) [DP two [NP [~~NP~~ apples] [PP of these eight apples]]]

But this predicts any rightward NP-adjunct is available, contrary to fact. Furthermore, it is not the complement of D which is deleted in their analysis. But this was the assumption required to unify Bareness and Extrapolability.

3.1 Some additional advantages to the Extraposition-plus-NP-deletion analysis

This analysis explains why partitive PPs with indefinite arguments are ungrammatical:

(30) *The researchers awoke {some/three/many} of participants.

of-NP_{indef} is known as a 'pseudopartitive'. Previous analyses stipulate that indefinites do not trigger post-syntactic *of*-insertion (Jackendoff, 1977, Matthewson, 2000, 2001). The NP-deletion analysis, on the other hand, reduces the contrast between quantified partitives/pseudopartitives to Selkirk's (1977) observation that pseudopartitive PPs cannot extrapose, but partitive PPs can (without committing to particular explanations of this fact):

(31) We ate [a lot t_1] yesterday [of *(the) left-over turkey]₁. (adapted; Selkirk, 1977)

The NP-deletion analysis also explains why the quantifier acts as if it is local to the ‘downstairs’ NP, despite *of the* intervening. Examples like (32) show either c-selection by the quantifier of a particular number feature (Chomsky, 1965, Abney, 1987, Wiltschko, 2008), or number-conditioned allomorphy (Bresnan, 1973, Bobaljik, 2012):

- (32) a. all_{SG/PL} of the beer(s)
 b. several*_{SG/PL} of the beer*(s)
 c. much of the beer
 d. *many of the beer
 (Intended: many units of the beer)

These are generally held to be highly-local, head-complement relations. The NP-deletion analysis claims that there is a duplicate of the downstairs noun in a local position.

- (33) a. [_{DP} much_D [_{NP} ~~beer~~ t_1] [_{PP} of the beer]₁]
 b. [_{DP} several_D [_{NP} ~~beers~~ t_1] [_{PP} of the beers]₁]

A quantifier which looks like it is selecting a number-feature within PP is in fact selecting a feature of its complement as usual. The deleted NP-complement must be there in order to satisfy the subcategorization restrictions of the quantifier locally.

3.2 Some potential issues with the Extraposition-plus-NP-deletion analysis

Despite the many advantages, there are some remaining issues. The first problem is that the analysis seems to overgenerate non-deleted forms:

(34)?? All cakes of the cakes

That is, it looks like the NP-deletion is obligatory. But as Hoeksema (1984) points out, such examples are ‘redundant, and therefore rather clumsy’, but not ungrammatical. He observes that the following are more acceptable:

- (35) a. two cooks of those we hired last summer (Stockwell et al., 1973:120)
 b. only two girls of the ten girls you recommended (Hoeksema, 1984:20)

So, NP-deletion is not *obligatory* ellipsis (cf. Elbourne, 2005 on third-person pronouns).

We now turn to another problem. Benz, Mendes and Salzmann (2024) object to the kind of derivation I have proposed (extraposition from elided NP). They object because PP-extraposition generally bleeds subextraction from PP (36).

- (36) a. I know who you bought two pictures of today, but I don't know who₁ you bought three pictures [PP of *t*₁] yesterday.
 b. *I know who you bought two pictures of today, but I don't know who₁ you bought three pictures *t*₂ yesterday [PP of *t*₁]₂.

But they note that in some NP-deletion cases, the stranded PP is transparent to subextraction (37). This suggests [PP of] has not extraposed.

- (37) I know who you bought two pictures of, but I don't know who₁ you bought three pictures [PP of *t*₁]

Worryingly, this reasoning extends beyond *of* in *picture of*, to partitive *of*:

- (38) I know what you ate all of, but I don't know what you ate only some of.

My suggestion – though I cannot defend it here for reasons of space – is that, while clause-level extraposition of PP bleeds subextraction, DP-internal extraposition of PP does not (relatedly, see Thoms, 2024 for DP-internal extraposition *feeding* movement out of DP).

Relational nouns also pose a problem. Richard Kayne (pers. comm.) asks why the examples in (39) are not synonymous:

- (39) a. some of our friends (by hypothesis, *some friends of our friends*)
 b. some friends of our friends

This is explained if the *of* which relates the nouns in *friends of John* is merely homophonous with the partitive *of* (Barker, 1998), and that PPs headed by this *of* resist extraposition.

That they do resist extraposition is shown in (40):

- (40) a. I met a friend of my best friend yesterday.
b. ??I met a friend t_1 yesterday [of my best friend]₁.

If relational-*of* PPs cannot extrapose, we block a relational/non-partitive reading of (39), just as we blocked the quantified pseudopartitive derivation.

A reviewer notes that comparatives and superlatives fit the Bareness generalization:

- (41) There were two/many mountains. We climbed the {high{er/est}, {more/most} challenging} (of them)

The adjective *high* in the positive form does not allow NP-deletion or partitives:

- (42) There were many mountains. We climbed the high *(ones) (*of them).

The contrast between (41) and (42) suggests that *-er/est* are responsible for licensing NP-deletion. This suggests, implausibly, that the NP *mountain* is the complement of *-er/est*. Conventional assumptions about degree morphemes (Abney, 1987, Kennedy, 1999) would find them adjoined to AP or NP (see Morzycki, 2016, §4.2 for overview). For reasons of space, I cannot pursue this interesting issue any further here.

The final issue is that extraposed XPs are generally freely-ordered (Drummond, 2013):

- (43) a. I tried [to give [pictures t_1 t_2] to John [that he'd like]₁] yesterday [of his dog]₂.
b. I tried [to give [pictures t_1 t_2] to John [of his dog]₁] yesterday [that he'd like]₂.

In quantified partitives, on the other hand, the partitive phrase must be leftmost:

- (44) a. The participants are sleeping. All [_{NP} participants t_1 t_2] [of them]₁ [that we are monitoring]₂ are in R.E.M.
b. * All [_{NP} participants t_1 t_2] [that we are monitoring]₁ [of them]₂ are in R.E.M.

But note that multiple modifiers *are* freely-ordered with respect to one another:

- (45) a. All [_{NP} participants $t_1 t_2 t_3$] [of them]₁ [that we are monitoring]₂ [from the subject-pool]₃ are currently in R.E.M.
 b. All [_{NP} participants $t_1 t_2 t_3$] [of them]₁ [from the subject-pool]₂ [that we are monitoring]₃ are currently in R.E.M.

I currently have no explanation for why the partitive phrase must stay closest, but the above facts suggest an argument/adjunct asymmetry (see Shin, 2016 and Shah, to appear for arguments that the partitive-PP is a complement, not a specifier or adjunct).

3.3 A brief extension to Spanish

A reviewer doubts that this account extends beyond English. They observe that in Spanish, (46) has only the quantified partitive reading and not the relational reading:

- (46) muchos de nuestros amigos
 ‘many of our friends’
 #‘many friends of our friends’

But unlike English, Spanish allows N to be unrealized without Extraposability holding:

- (47) a. el libro rojo y el libro verde
 the book red and the book green
 ‘the red book and the green one’
 b. el amigo de mi amigo y el amigo de Juan
 the friend of my friend and the friend of Juan

They conclude that if (46) involves a deleted *amigos*, Extraposability cannot be what explains the relational reading’s absence (as I claimed for (39)).

But the examples in (47) are not quantified partitives. In fact, it seems that Extraposability does still hold in Spanish quantified partitives. This is suggested by (48):

- (48) *muchos verde de nuestros libros
 Intended: ‘Many green ones out of our books’

My analysis explains this: [_{AP} *verde*] is unavailable in (48) because it cannot extrapose, and Spanish quantified partitives require NP-deletion, just as in English.

I claim further that the cases in (47) do not involve NP-deletion, and so do not provide appropriate baselines. The examples in (47) behave exactly how the silent noun hypothesis (which I rejected for English) predicts: all NP-modifiers are permissible, including adjectives which cannot extrapose, and there seem to be no restrictions on which determiners can appear in sentences like (47) (see also Kornfeld and Saab, 2004 who are explicit that the silent element can be just a single head). And, as the reviewer notes, the reading received is that of *one*-anaphora. Thus, following Panagiotidis (2003), Cabredo Hofherr (2006), and Gagnon (2013), I suggest that the examples in (47) reflect the availability in Romance of a silent anaphor similar to English *one*, with the difference that the Spanish silent N-anaphor does not mandate a count antecedent. Spanish then allows NP-deletion *as well as* a silent N. But Spanish quantified partitives still require NP-deletion; this explains the ungrammaticality of (48). So, the relational reading's absence in (46) is still plausibly explained by Extraposability.

4 Conclusion

I have decomposed the 'quantified partitive' construction into two independent pieces: (i) partitive PPs can extrapose, (ii) some quantifiers can delete their complements.

- (49) a. Much [_{NP}-cake], much [_{NP}-cake *t*_I] [of the cake]_I
 b. Many [_{NP}-cakes], many [_{NP}-cakes *t*_I] [of the cakes]_I

This analysis completely unifies quantified partitives with bare quantifiers, explaining why exactly the same quantifiers appear in both, and why only extraposable NP-modifiers are available in either construction. It also avoids the overgeneration problems of a silent noun analysis as well as the undergeneration problems of a 'surface true' analysis. In addition, it accounts for why the quantifier behaves as if it is local to the NP in the partitive PP, and reduces the unavailability of quantified pseudopartitives to the independently observable non-extraposability of pseudopartitives.

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Notes

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Abstract

This squib argues that English ‘quantified partitives’ like *some of the sheep* are underlyingly *some sheep of the sheep* with the partitive-PP extraposed and the stranded NP *sheep* deleted. This analysis unifies quantified partitives with bare quantifiers (quantifiers which can delete their NP-complements), explaining why exactly the same quantifiers are available in both. It also explains why only extraposable NP-modifiers are available in either construction. The NP-deletion analysis avoids problems faced by previous analyses, including those that posit silent nouns, like *some UNIT of the sheep* and ‘surface true’ analyses, which posit neither silent elements nor deletion.

Keywords: ellipsis, stranding, quantifiers, partitives, extraposition, modification